

**"WOMEN WILL
NOT PAY TAX
UNTIL THE
WORLD ENDS."**

NWANYEREUWA, 1929



◀ **Fashion victim**

This Igbo woman, photographed in 1922, wears immense brass anklets called *ogba*. These costly and cumbersome fashion accessories were a status symbol, as the wearer could not perform normal domestic duties.



The revolt was sparked by what became a notorious dispute between a woman called Nwanyereuwa, in the village of Oloko, and Mark Emereuwa, a man conducting a detailed census of wives, children, and livestock in each household for tax purposes. Traditionally, Igbo women had not been subject to taxation, so when he asked Nwanyereuwa for information that would be used to tax her, it was the final straw. Nwanyereuwa spread the word by sending out palm leaves as an invitation to women in neighboring villages to join the rebellion: each woman passed a palm leaf on to another woman. As a result, nearly 10,000 women gathered to protest against the local warrant chief, demanding his removal. Nwanyereuwa advocated nonviolent actions, including “sitting on” or “making war on” men by performing songs and dances to ridicule them. The women also tore down the roofs of buildings owned by European companies.

Other villages in Calabar and Owerri followed the example of Oloko, and the growing rebellion—of not only Igbo but also Ibibio, Andoni, Orgoni, Bonny, and Opobo women—challenged British rule.

Colonial troops fired shots at the women, but they stood firm. The British relented, colonial administration was restructured, warrant chiefs were removed, and the plan to tax women ended. Crucially, the protest ensured that Igbo women once more took part in political life, and that the Igbo people regained some of their power to self-govern.